

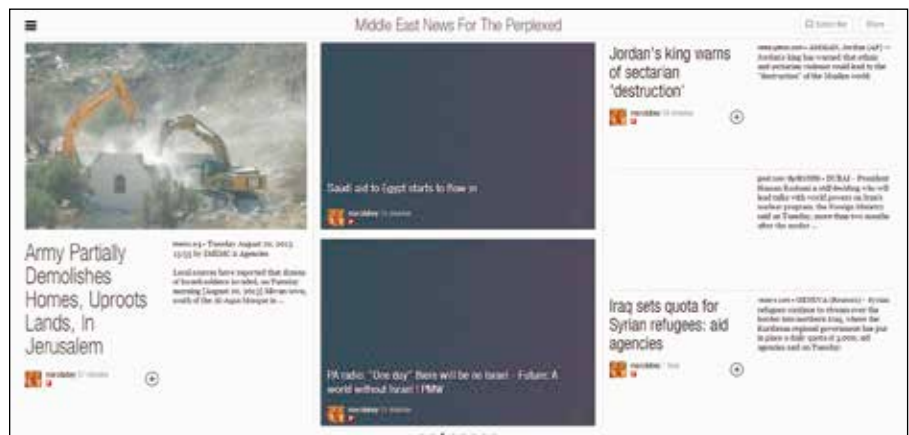
ticular friends, reactions to a particular post and your inclination to interact with a particular type of post), this is what's responsible for creating your newsfeed, so none of that matters. As a result, Facebook (with the help of your own unconscious or conscious actions) tries to set up a filter between you and a vast pool of news/content, only letting in things that comfort you or are considered clickworthy by you.

This is the filter bubble Eli Pariser has been speaking about since 2010. He also spoke about how Google searches were being tailored to fit a user's search history – a phenomenon that's actually difficult to replicate. However, the concept of a user being “shielded” from information is starkly apparent on Facebook.

News you want, not news you need

But why is this a topic worth talking about? Surely, people very seldom rely on Facebook for news? That assumption is no longer true, at least in parts of the world where Facebook is intrinsically part of a person's daily life. According to a study published by the Pew Research Centre in September 2012, 33% of young American adults (those under the age of 30) relied on social networks for news. Considering the vast leaps we're taking to catch up in matters of technology consumption to our Western counterparts, how long do you think will it be before young and educated middle-class Indian adults begin relying on Facebook (or other social networks) for a majority of their news, especially since Facebook already takes up such a large part of our daily lives.

Pariser noted in his excellent TED Talk how algorithms were giving us access to “the news we want, but not the one we need.” The Facebook example mentioned earlier represents that phenomenon. People who rely on social networks for news tend to be exposed to topics that they're more likely to find comfortable rather than topics that they should know about but aren't inclined to follow up on. While the priority of stories in newspapers and TV news broadcasts is decided by editors, on social networks, you're essentially playing the role of editor.



An example of a user-created Flipboard mag on the Middle East

The upside: news curation

Playing ‘Editor’ and wielding the ability to curate news to our exact requirements can be a very powerful tool. In fact, the current availability of a huge number of news curation tools for smartphones, tablets and PCs means that we can keep ourselves up to date thanks to the constant flow of information on topics that we would otherwise not have access to, even through newspapers or TV news. Knowing the latest breaking news on a subject that matters to you as it happens even when we're nowhere next to a TV set is a privilege we shouldn't take for granted.

One of the biggest tools intended for this purpose is RSS (Rich Site Summary, also dubbed Really Simple Syndication), a format that allows regularly updated online content such as news to be viewed and exported in a standardised format. Even though Google Reader, the most widely used RSS-powered news aggregation tool recently called it quits, RSS is still used by a wide number of tools in

order to help users pick and choose content and sources.

There are a ton of tools out there that will help you tailor your newsfeed according to the kind of content you want. Flipboard, Pulse Reader and Feedly are already well known for their ability to do this and are extremely popular amongst smartphone and tablet users. These tools not only let you choose specific topics you may be interested in (such as Arts and Entertainment, Politics, Sports etc.) but also let you add news sources by exact keywords as well as individual sites. If you're looking to go beyond what social network algorithms believe you should read, take some time out to personalise one of these tools with topics and sources that interest you. Also throw in some new sources that cover topics that you wouldn't usually follow or have never delved into. It will expand your mind and broaden your perspective.

Keep in mind that these tools will work best if you actually make it a point to carefully select trusted sources and news. A tool like Flipboard actually also makes it very easy to succumb to convenience if you just decide to stick to your social network feeds or the pre-packaged topics on offer. At the end of the day, these tools, when used right, should help you create a library of news that goes beyond what your social network's newsfeed has to offer. 



Eli Pariser speaking about the Filter Bubble at a TED conference